

5.10.2 Life cycle assessment and recycling

5.10.2.1 Life cycle assessment

Content	Key opportunities for skills development
Life cycle assessments (LCAs) are carried out to assess the environmental impact of products in each of these stages: • extracting and processing raw materials • manufacturing and packaging • use and operation during its lifetime • disposal at the end of its useful life, including transport and distribution at each stage. Use of water, resources, energy sources and production of some wastes can be fairly easily quantified. Allocating numerical values to pollutant effects is less straightforward and requires value judgements, so LCA is not a purely objective process. Selective or abbreviated LCAs can be devised to evaluate a product but these can be misused to reach pre-determined conclusions, eg in support of claims for advertising purposes. Students should be able to carry out simple comparative LCAs for shopping bags made from plastic and paper.	WS 1.3, 4, 5 LCAs should be done as a comparison of the impact on the environment of the stages in the life of a product, and only quantified where data is readily available for energy, water, resources and wastes. Interpret LCAs of materials or products given appropriate information. MS 1a Recognise and use expressions in decimal form. MS 1c Use ratios, fractions and percentages. MS 1d Make estimates of the results of simple calculations. MS 2a Use an appropriate number of significant figures. MS 4a Translate information between graphical and numeric form.

5.10.2.2 Ways of reducing the use of resources

Content	Key opportunities for skills development
The reduction in use, reuse and recycling of materials by end users reduces the use of limited resources, use of energy sources, waste and environmental impacts. Metals, glass, building materials, clay ceramics and most plastics are produced from limited raw materials. Much of the energy for the processes comes from limited resources. Obtaining raw materials from the Earth by quarrying and mining causes environmental impacts. Some products, such as glass bottles, can be reused. Glass bottles can be crushed and melted to make different glass products. Other products cannot be reused and so are recycled for a different use. Metals can be recycled by melting and recasting or reforming into different products. The amount of separation required for recycling depends on the material and the properties required of the final product. For example, some scrap steel can be added to iron from a blast furnace to reduce the amount of iron that needs to be extracted from iron ore. Students should be able to evaluate ways of reducing the use of limited resources, given appropriate information.	